

year. The average first-innings total is 255.6, and the average winning total is 281.6. Harmanpreet herself, ahead of the England ODIs, stated that India wants to make 300-plus scores a habit. The side will be better placed to do so if she can settle early and unleash her naturally explosive style of scoring.

Marks of success

While India has more or less decided on its top six or seven batters, the bowling department continues to pose headaches — not all of them the good kind.

The side's most prolific quick, Renuka Singh Thakur, has missed a chunk of the season due to injury. Pooja Vastrakar has been out of action for even longer. Shreyanka Patil remains under medical observation at the BCCI's Centre for Excellence.

But in their absence, a crop of feisty youngsters has fearlessly gone about staking a claim for a World Cup spot. Pacer Kranti Goud and left-arm spinner Shree Charani were two big positives from India's tour of the British Isles. Charani took home the Player of the Series award in the T20I leg, while Kranti's six-wicket haul helped India rout England and seal the ODI series 2-1 in Durham.

Both fast learners and unfazed by the occasion or the veterans they face, Kranti and Charani will be closely watched during Australia's visit in a few weeks. Sneha wasn't rolling in wickets, but her unplayable overs, stingy economy rate, and handy batting make her an obvious pick. Amanjot Kaur has also impressed, taking on new-ball

duties while providing quick runs when needed.

India has always fielded an impressive array of spinners. Deepti Sharma has emerged as a cut above the rest, finding a way to evolve and reinvent even as tweekers come and go around her. But that ever-changing pool has seen some solid talent.

Against England, Indian spinners took 25 of the 40 English wickets to fall in the T20I leg. Their English counterparts could only manage nine of the 23 Indian scalps claimed. The Sophie Ecclestone-led attack bounced back in the ODIs, balancing the scales and finding form. But India had the momentum, and an England side in transition — with a new leadership group — was no match.

But perhaps the biggest shot in the arm for this team has been its elevated quality in the field.

India's core of young players now features athletes who aren't afraid to put their bodies on the line. There was a time when acrobatic brilliance from Harleen or Radha Yadav was the only means to feel hopeful about India's ability as a fielding unit. Holding on to tough catches and deploying direct hits have become the norm — a result of years of hard work and dedicated camps, like the one at the National Centre of Excellence before the side's British sojourn, paying rich dividends.

Muzumdar, when he took over, spoke of wanting his batters to pitch in with the ball. As part of that experiment, we got to see Smriti's own half pace-half spin action. Realistically though, Pratika is the only one

Improved fielding: India's core of young players now features athletes who aren't afraid to put their bodies on the line.

doubling up to bowl regularly from the top six. When viewed against a side like Australia, which is stacked with two-skilled all-rounders, it might feel like India is a few cards short in the game.

India is in a far better place in terms of preparation for the ODI World Cup than it was for the T20 showpiece in Dubai last year, when the No.3 spot was undecided just days before the opening game. There have been A tours to Australia to test bench strength, and the Women's Premier League has proven to be a crucial breeding ground for selectors to broaden their national setup options.

Australia, with its reputation, ruthlessness, and rigour, will pose a tough challenge ahead of the World Cup and provide crucial final notes for the think tank. There's no reason 2025 shouldn't be India's year to be crowned champion.

But will it?

INDIA'S ODI RUN SINCE THE 2024 T20 WORLD CUP



2-1
vs New Zealand (home)

0-3
vs Australia (away)

3-0
vs West Indies (home)

3-0
vs Ireland (home)

2-1
vs England (away)

4-1
Won tri-series against Sri Lanka and South Africa (away)

